Officially, the Soviets claimed the former General Secretary was suffering severe cardiac problems requiring treatment at a better-equipped hospital in the USSR. German authorities, it later transpired, were given one-and-a-half hours' notice before the flight on 13 March 1991. Enraged by his sudden escape, German government spokesman Dieter Vogel said the move would 'cast a certain shadow on relations, at least for a while. But of course, we have a fundamental interest in keeping our relations as positive, friendly and reasonable as possible.'26

The deep irony of Honecker's flight was in the fact that he permitted Gorbachev, the man who he considered his biggest ideological enemy, to help him.

In an interview with West German newspapers, Friedrich Wolff expressed surprise at the drama, saying many Soviets had considered the matter embarrassing. 'And, of course,' he added, 'there is also something like solidarity with the old fellow-fighter. Soviet wishes were known, and there has probably long been some kind of secret agreement.'27 However, when Bonn demanded Russia hand back Honecker on 15 March, Moscow's foreign ministry spokesman Vitaly Churkin admitted moving the East German was a 'technical violation' of Germany's sovereignty, but ruled out sending him back.28 Bonn then accused Moscow of breaking international law and trampling on treaties between the two countries. For a short while thereafter, the situation cooled. Throughout the summer, Erich and Margot convalesced at a dacha in Moscow's suburbs. It was only after an attempted coup against Gorbachev in August,29 that Germany ramped-up pressure and sent a new extradition request.

This time, though, the call was publicly supported by Boris Yeltsin, the new President of the Russian Soviet Socialist Federal Republic but opposed by Gorbachev (whose influence was in steep decline) who continued to protect him from extradition.

'I intend to go back to Germany but only if this illegal arrest warrant that is in force for unknown reasons be withdrawn,' Honecker told a journalist from ARD who had travelled to Moscow to conduct what the network billed as 'the interview of the century'. 'I have no intention to quench their thirst for revenge. The Federal Republic of Germany has no right to